

The Distraction-Free YouTube Setup Guide

A Complete Manual for Installing and Customizing Your Personal Focus Interface

Introduction: What This Project Does

This manual walks you step-by-step through turning YouTube from an algorithm-driven distraction platform into a clean, intentional workspace.

By running this custom browser extension locally, you get:

- A blank homepage with zero recommendations, feeds, or trending videos.
- A centered, AI-style direct search box with no search history or predictive dropdowns.
- An interactive, customizable mind map with topic cards that link directly to lectures, playlists, or search terms.
- Strict built-in blocking of Shorts, Games (Playables), comments, and distracting feeds.

Phase 1: Downloading the Code from GitHub

Follow these steps to download the source files to your computer.

Step 1: Download the Repository

1. Visit the project's GitHub repository page in your browser.
2. Locate the green `<> Code` button near the top right of the file listing.
3. Click **Download ZIP**.
4. Save the `.zip` file to an accessible location (e.g., your `Downloads` folder or `Desktop`).

Step 2: Extract the Folder

1. Right-click the downloaded `.zip` file and choose **Extract All...** (Windows) or double-click it (macOS).
2. Choose a permanent location for the extracted folder (for example:
`C:\Users\YourName\Documents\FocusTubeExtension`).

Note: Do not delete or move this folder after installation. Your browser will read directly from this location each time it launches.

Step 3: Verify the File Structure

Open the folder and make sure it contains the three primary files:

- `manifest.json` (Extension configuration file)
- `clean.css` (Visual styling, feed blockers, and canvas rules)
- `script.js` (Search redirection, mind-map logic, and keyword shields)

Phase 2: Installing in Your Browser

This extension works on any Chromium-based browser, including **Brave**, **Google Chrome**, **Microsoft Edge**, and **Opera**.

Step 1: Open the Extensions Page

- In **Brave**, type `brave://extensions` into your address bar and press **Enter**.
- In **Chrome**, type `chrome://extensions` into your address bar and press **Enter**.
- In **Edge**, type `edge://extensions` into your address bar and press **Enter**.

Step 2: Enable Developer Mode

- Look in the top-right corner of the Extensions page.
- Toggle the switch labeled **Developer mode** to the **ON** position.

Step 3: Load the Unpacked Extension

1. Click the **Load unpacked** button in the top-left toolbar.
2. In the file picker window, navigate to your extracted folder (select the folder containing `manifest.json`).
3. Click **Select Folder**.

You should now see a card titled **Unhook Personal Hardcode** (or the name designated in your `manifest.json`) in your extensions list.

Phase 3: Testing and Using the Interface

1. Open a new tab and go to `[https://www.youtube.com](https://www.youtube.com)`.
2. **First-Load Check:** You should see a blank, clean dark canvas with a centered cloud and your search bar—no home feed, no Shorts, and no top banner.
3. **Running a Search:** Type a topic into the center input box and press **Enter**. It will navigate directly to YouTube's search results with the top masthead completely hidden.
4. **Interactive Mind Map:**
 - **Drag Cards:** Click and hold any topic card to position it around your cloud. The dashed lines will follow dynamically.
 - **Add Topics:** Click the **Add a Topic** button on the bottom bar to open the modal dialog, select a pastel color, give the topic a name, and attach a search query or playlist URL (up to 7 topics maximum).
 - **Delete Topics:** Hover over any card and click the small ✕ icon in the corner to remove it.

Phase 4: Updating the Code Later

Whenever you edit `clean.css` or `script.js`, the browser needs to reload the updated files:

1. Open `brave://extensions` (or `chrome://extensions`).
2. Find your extension's card.
3. Click the circular **Reload** arrow icon on the bottom right of the card.
4. Go back to YouTube and press `Ctrl + F5` (or `Cmd + Shift + R` on Mac) to refresh the page cache.

Phase 5: Troubleshooting & Support

If an element does not render properly or if YouTube updates its layout structure, follow these diagnostic steps:

Issue	Cause	Fix
Red Errors button appears on the card	Syntax or timing error in <code>script.js</code>	Click Errors on the card, read the line number, click Clear all , and verify your script matches the latest code.
Brief flash of YouTube feeds on load	<code>manifest.json</code> not running at early stage	Ensure <code>"run_at": "document_start"</code> is declared for both CSS and JS scripts in <code>manifest.json</code> .
Cards do not save positions	Browser local storage cleared	Dragging positions persist via <code>localStorage</code> . Avoid clearing site data for YouTube if you want positions preserved.

Need Additional Help?

If you run into an error you cannot solve, you can get immediate technical assistance by opening [Google Gemini](#) and pasting this prompt template:

"I am running a local Chromium extension for YouTube that uses a custom `clean.css` and `script.js` to create a distraction-free mind-map homepage and direct URL search. I encountered the following issue: [PASTE YOUR EXACT ERROR OR ISSUE HERE]. Can you inspect my setup and guide me through the fix?"